# US SPECIAL OPERATIONS FORCES

Over the half century since the US Army Special Forces, popularly known as the Green Berets, were tentatively founded in 1952, units devoted to unconventional warfare, counter-insurgency, and counter-terrorism have proliferated in the US armed forces. Since 1987 all have been grouped together under US Special Operations Command in Tampa, Florida. By the early 21st century there were estimated to be around 50,000 men in the US military devoted to special operations.

The Green Berets, primarily based at Fort Bragg, North Carolina, became a high-profile formation after winning the patronage of US President John F Kennedy in his drive to develop a counter-insurgency capacity in the early 1960s. The Berets' reputation was confirmed by their determined efforts to organize mountain tribesmen as anti-communist forces during the Vietnam War. Vietnam also saw the re-formation of the US Army Rangers as a long-range patrol force. Another product of that period's interest in countering guerrilla warfare was the US Navy SEAL (Sea-Air-Land) teams, founded in 1962 and first sent into combat in Vietnam in 1966, specializing in riverine operations. The 1970s brought a different emphasis, with the rise of international terrorism. The US Army's Combat Applications Group, popularly known as Delta Force, was set up by Colonel Charles Beckwith in 1977 primarily as a counter-terrorist warfare unit. It has remained one of the most secretive of unconventional warfare organizations, perhaps partly because the highly publicized failure of its attempt to free American hostages held in Iran in 1980 was such an embarrassment.

US special operations forces have played a prominent role in recent conflicts, notably the invasions of Iraq and Afghanistan, and the prolonged counter-insurgency campaigns in both those countries. The US Defense Department envisages that they will have a crucial future role in countering the threat of global terrorism networks.




**M16A1 ASSAULT RIFLE WITH M203 GRENADE LAUNCHER**

**Weapons**
Special forces throughout the world use army-issue weapons. In the US, favourites include the M16 assault rifle and the MP7 submachine-gun.




**MP7 SUBMACHINE-GUN**

> "TRAIN FOR WAR, FIGHT TO WIN, DEFEAT OUR NATION'S ENEMIES."
>
> **US NAVY SEAL CODE OF HONOUR** EXCERPT



**Small Boat Unit**
US Navy SEALs on a special operation with an SBU (Small Boat Unit) in Panama, 1994. In the foreground a camouflaged soldier bears an M16A3 rifle fitted with an M209 grenade launcher.